OPERATIONS IN THE 1980S

On 2 July 1972, India and Pakistan signed the Simla Agreement, specifying that both sides' forces were to be withdrawn to their respective sides of the border. In Jammu & Kashmir, the Line of Control (LC) resulting from the ceasefire was formally established. Both states agreed to refrain from altering the LC unilaterally, to refrain from the use of military power and to withdraw their forces along the LC. This resulted in peace in the region for some years, but the 1980s saw the Indian Army involved in several operations. In March–April 1984, the Indian Army launched Operation *Meghdoot* to occupy the Saltoro Ridge Line in Siachen. This was followed by Operation *Chequerboard* (spring 1987), in response to the Chinese incursion in Sumdorong Chu in Eastern Arunachal Pradesh; Operation *Pawan* (11–25 October 1987) in Sri Lanka; and Operation *Cactus* (3 November 1988), to reinstate and safeguard the government in the Maldives.

Siachen, 1984–88

The Siachen Glacier, 76km long, is situated in Jammu & Kashmir. It falls from an altitude of about 5,500m at a point known as Indira Kol, to about 3,350m at its terminus. To the east of the glacier is the main Karakoram mountain range, while to its west is the Saltoro Ridge, which serves as a divide that prevents direct linking of Pakistan Occupied Kashmir with China. Just south-west of the glacier is a point on the map called NJ 9842. The Karachi Agreement of 1949 delineated the India and Pakistan separation only up to this point after which the line of separation would continue 'thence North to the Glacier'. India claims that the line of separation continues roughly north from point NJ 9842 along the Saltoro Range while the Pakistani claim line runs from NJ 9842 eastwards right up to the Karakoram Pass.